

Small Team Workflows 2026

How 412 small teams collect, decide and hand over work



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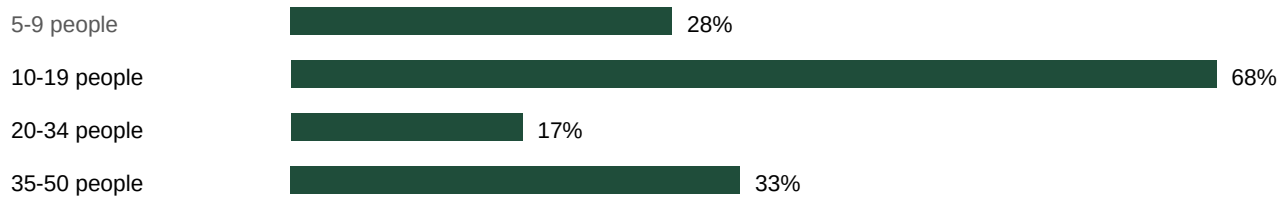


1. About this report

Small Teams Weekly surveyed 412 fictional teams of 5 to 50 people in Germany, Austria and Switzerland between May and July 2026. Respondents were team leads, operations staff and founders. All figures in this report are invented for a training exercise.

The survey asked how requests arrive, who decides what happens next, and how work is handed over when someone is away.

Figure 3: responses by team size (illustrative, fictional)



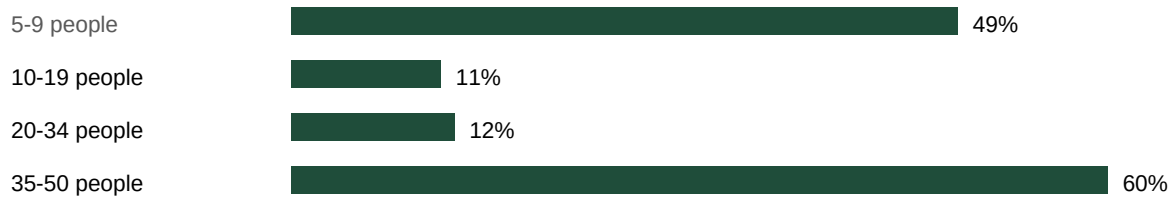


1. About this report (continued)

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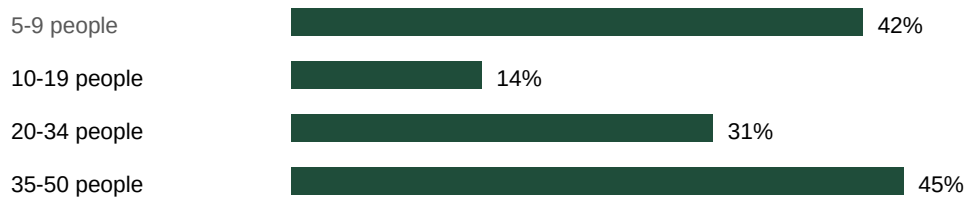


2. How requests arrive

Most teams receive requests through more than one channel. The median team uses three: email, a chat tool and conversations in person.

Requests that arrive by chat are the least likely to be written down. Teams said they 'remember' them, until they do not.

Figure 5: responses by team size (illustrative, fictional)



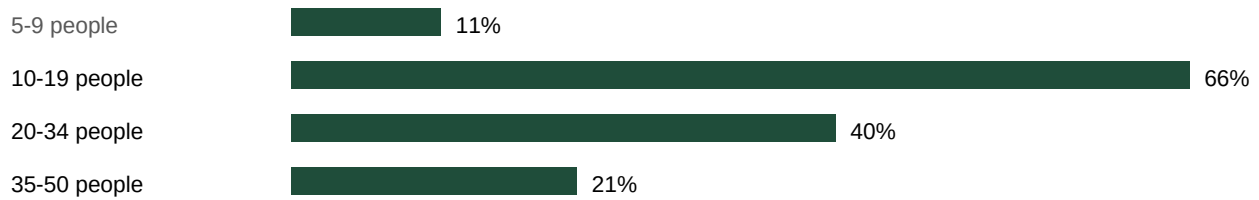


2. How requests arrive (continued)

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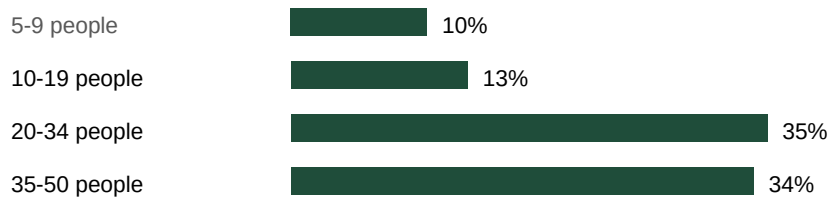


3. Who decides

In two thirds of teams, one person decides the owner of each new request. In the rest, whoever sees the request first takes it.

Teams with a named decider report fewer forgotten requests, but also longer waiting times when that person is away.

Figure 7: responses by team size (illustrative, fictional)



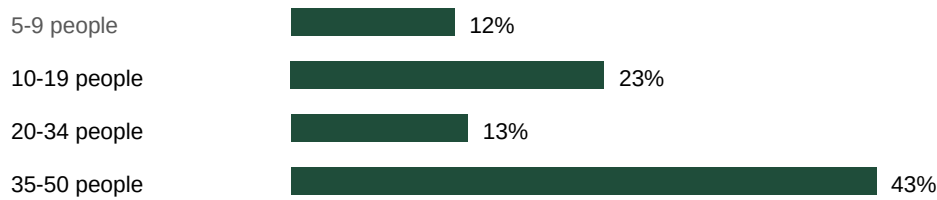


3. Who decides (continued)

In two thirds of teams, one person decides the owner of each new request. In the rest, whoever sees the request first takes it.

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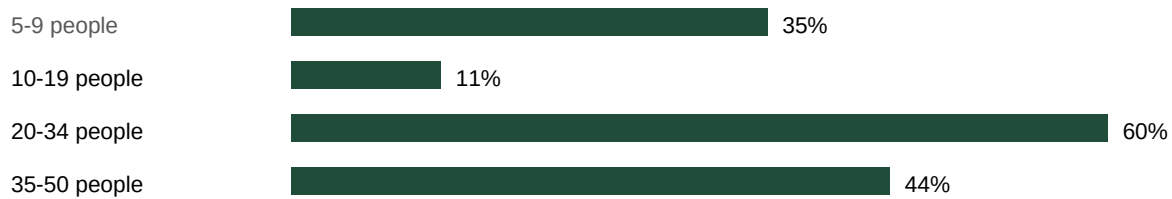


4. Missing information

Almost every team said that requests often arrive incomplete. The most common missing details are deadlines, budget and the person to contact.

Asking for missing details takes, by the teams' own estimate, between 10 and 30 minutes per request.

Figure 9: responses by team size (illustrative, fictional)



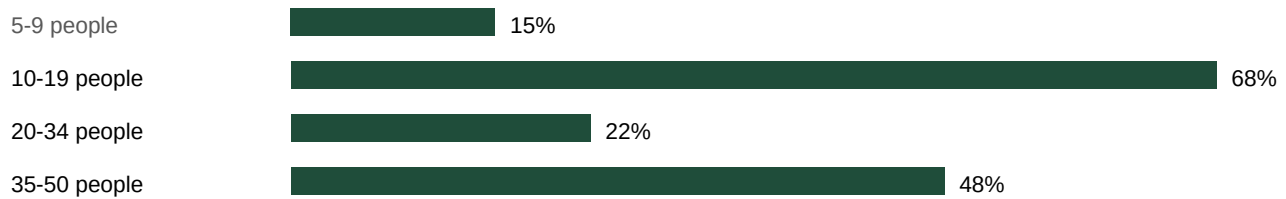


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Figure 10: responses by team size (illustrative, fictional)





5. Review queues

A review queue is a list of requests that a person must look at before anything happens. Teams that use one say it makes problems visible early.

The most useful review queues are short. Teams recommend that each item says what is missing and who can supply it.

Figure 11: responses by team size (illustrative, fictional)



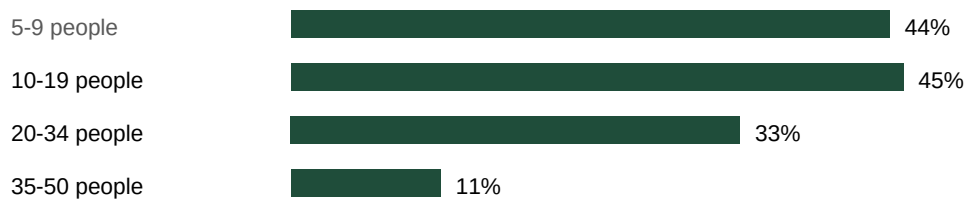


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Figure 12: responses by team size (illustrative, fictional)



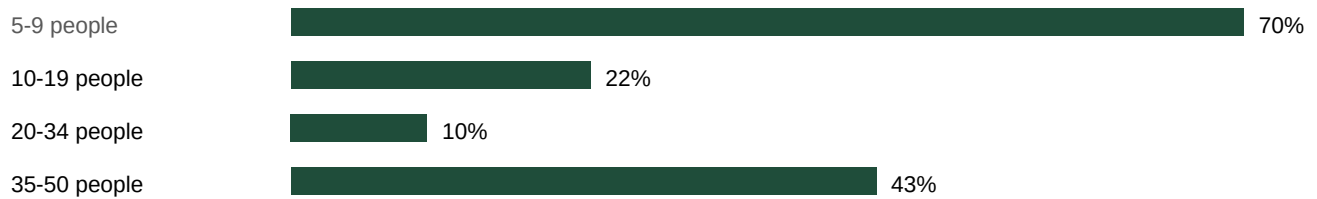


6. Handover

When someone is away, their open requests are the most likely to stall. Only a minority of teams keep a written handover note.

Teams that keep one describe it as a short page: open items, who is waiting, and where the files are.

Figure 13: responses by team size (illustrative, fictional)



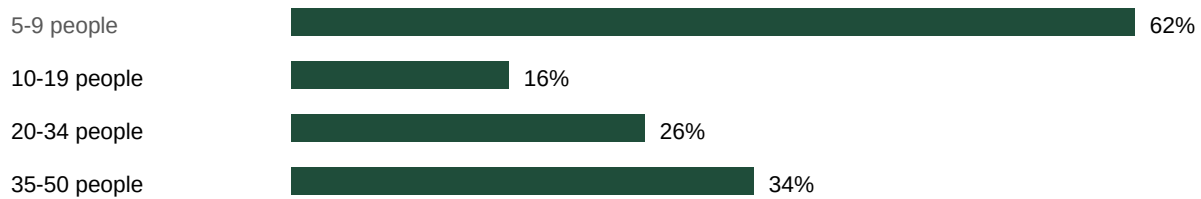


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Figure 14: responses by team size (illustrative, fictional)



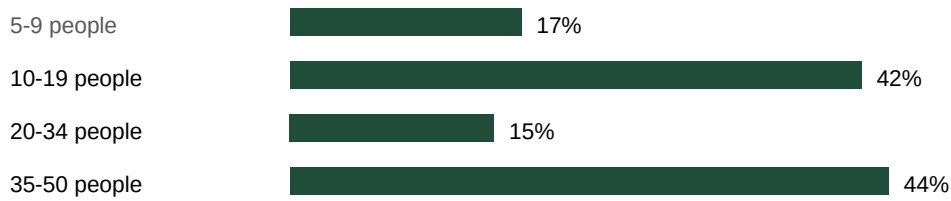


7. Tools

Spreadsheets remain the most common tool for tracking requests. Dedicated ticket tools are used mainly by teams above 30 people.

Several teams use a notes app as a database: one page per request with a status field.

Figure 15: responses by team size (illustrative, fictional)



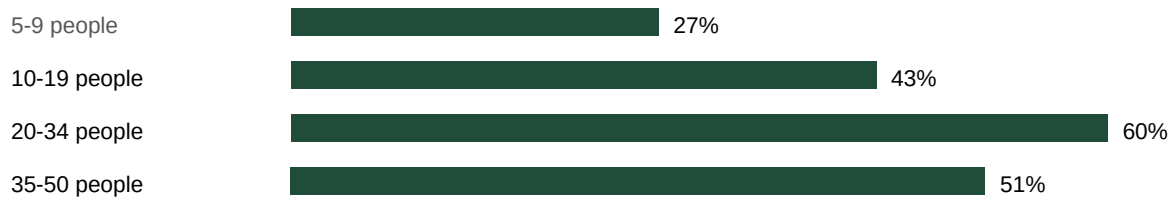


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Figure 16: responses by team size (illustrative, fictional)





8. Shared intake

41% of small teams use a shared intake form, such as a web form or a shared spreadsheet that everyone fills in the same way. 23% rely on email alone. The remaining teams mix chat, email and in-person requests without a single place to collect them.



Teams with a shared intake form reported that fewer requests were lost, but said the form only works if everyone uses it, including the team lead.

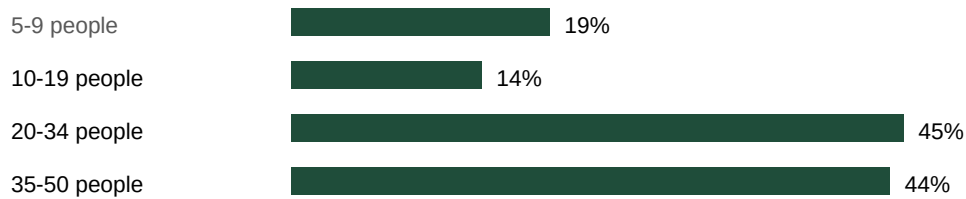


9. Automation (continued)

Few teams automate more than reminders. The most common automation is a weekly summary email.

Teams were cautious about tools that send messages on their own. Most want a person to approve anything that leaves the team.

Figure 18: responses by team size (illustrative, fictional)



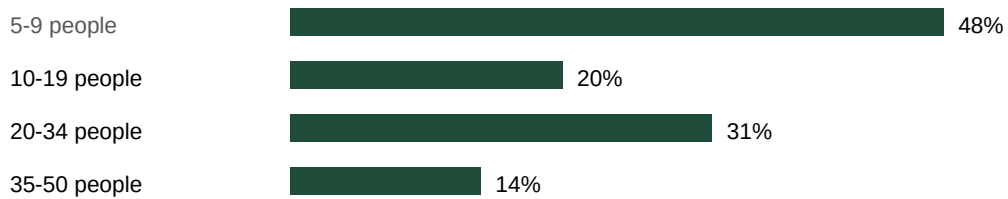


10. Recommendations

Write every request down in one place. Name who decides. Show what is missing. Keep a short handover note.

Start small: one form, one list and one weekly review are enough for most teams.

Figure 19: responses by team size (illustrative, fictional)





10. Recommendations (continued)

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Figure 20: responses by team size (illustrative, fictional)

